Making your candle cup holder

We're going to make our candle holder using some metal spinning techniques to mould the metal to a very small curve. Metal spinning does have its own tool requirements, but I've improvised here and will be using an old worn out 6mm bowl gouge on a hollowing tool rest

8 I sourced my metal sheet from the internet, buying brass and copper in small pieces (300 x 100 x 1mm). If you've never attempted metal spinning before then start with copper as it spins far more easily

9 Using the whole width of the sheet and a pair of dividers, scribe your 100mm discs, leaving a centre point in the discs

10 Now, using a pair of tin snips, cut the circles out and remember that once cut, the edges will be sharp. A pair of gloves might be wise if at all unsure or new to this process. Once the shapes are cut, file the edges back to your scribe lines and tidy up the disc

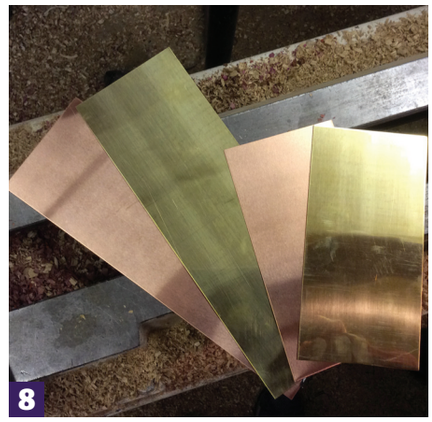
11 In order to shape your metal discs they need to be formed over a mould. Here I've turned a simple curve from a piece of scrap timber. In the centre leave a small centre point and a 30mm-wide flat to press the copper disc against

12 In the tailstock, use a heavy duty tailstock centre with a small turned wooden ring to sit over the centre, which creates enough friction against the copper disc to keep it turning. When making this wooden collar, make sure just a small amount of the tailstock centre point is protruding to enable you to centre the copper disc

13 Use the centre hole in the copper disc and the point from the tailstock centre to press the disc against the mould firmly. Apply a lot of pressure against the disc and mould, but try not to have too much of the tailstock quill exposed in order to keep things as ridgid as possible

14 At this stage, the tool I'm using is an improvised 6mm bowl gouge, at the end of its life and where the flute has gone. I ground the tip of the tool until it was a smooth convex curve and then polished it until it shone, as you would the back of a carving gouge. It's really important that the back of the tool is completely smooth to stop too much heat from friction

15 Use the tool in a hollowing gate and the tool below centre, levering the copper disc around the turned former. To help reduce friction, coat the copper disc as it spins with wax (candle- or wood-), which works perfectly for the small curve we're making here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